

The Greek orders

By the fifth century BCE, Greek architecture had attained a purity of style, harmony and technical expertise. A century earlier, architects and stonemasons had developed a system of rules to use in all buildings. These rules became known as the orders, and are most easily seen in the styles of their columns.

A Greek column, normally comprising a capital, shaft and base, came in three types. The Doric, uniquely, has no base, and the fluted shaft rises up to a plain convex capital. Examples can be seen in the Parthenon. The Ionic is taller and slimmer, with flat bands separating the flutes on the shaft; there may be figurative reliefs around the base, and a female 'caryatid' figure may stand in place of a fluted shaft. Ionic capitals have two pairs of scroll-like volutes, with architraves that consist of three horizontal planes, each projecting slightly, and a plain or sculptured frieze. Similar to Ionic but more ornate, Corinthian capitals are often decorated with carved acanthus leaves and four scrolls, or sometimes with carved lotus or palm leaves.

